

Running Costs & Launch Plan

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The short version

	1,000 users	10,000 users
Monthly running costs	~\$250–280	~\$1,680–1,880
Costs Per User / month	~0.27	~\$0.18

These are the all-in costs to keep the app running — servers, database, text messages to users, map lookups, and basic monitoring. Costs go down per user as you grow because the fixed costs (server, database) spread across more people.

What you're paying for

Service	What it does	Cost at 1k / 10k users
Hosting (Railway)	Runs the app and website	\$20–50 / \$100–300 mo
Database (MongoDB)	Stores all user accounts, plans, and activity	\$60 / \$140 mo
Notifications (Twilio SMS)	Sends texts to users — invites, reminders, etc.	\$130 / \$1,165 mo
Maps (Google Places)	Lets users search for venues when making plans	\$0 / \$200 mo
Error monitoring (Sentry)	Alerts you when something breaks	\$26 / \$26 mo
Domain name	Your web address	~\$15 / year

Notifications are the biggest variable cost. If you want to lower the bill, there are two levers: send fewer texts, or switch to a different notification method (see next section).

Notifications: two ways to reach users

The app sends notifications to users (invites, reminders, weekend digests). There are two ways to do this — both work, but they trade off cost vs. reach.

	Text messages (SMS)	Web notifications
How it reaches users	Sent to their phone number, like any text	Pops up in their browser or on their phone home screen
What users have to do	Nothing — just sign up with their phone	Click “allow notifications” and (on iPhone) save the app to their home screen
Will every user get it?	Yes	Only the ones who opt in — roughly 10–25% on phones, 30–50% on computers
Cost per message	About 1 cent	Free
Cost at 10k users	~\$1,165 / month	~\$0–10 / month
Pre-launch paperwork	Yes — US carriers require a 1–3 week registration	None
Build time	Already done	1–2 weeks of dev work

Option A: Text messages

Notifications arrive as a text on the user's phone. The user signs up with their number and that's it — no permissions, no installing anything.

The good:

- Reaches everyone. No opt-in to worry about.
- Zero friction for the user — they just get a text.
- Already built. Ship now.
- Works great for re-engagement — users who've drifted away still get texts.

The trade-offs:

- Costs real money per text. At 10,000 users, that's ~\$1,165/month.
- US carriers require registration paperwork before you can launch — takes 1–3 weeks. Miss it and your texts get blocked.
- Plain text only — no images, no buttons. Just a message with a link.
- International users cost more and have different rules in every country.

Option B: Web notifications

Notifications pop up on the user's phone or computer the same way a notification from any app does. The user has to grant permission first — and on iPhone, they have to add the website to their home screen for it to work.

The good:

- Basically free, no matter how many users you have.

- No carrier paperwork to deal with.
- Richer notifications — icons, images, tappable buttons.
- Easier to measure who's clicking and engaging.

The trade-offs:

- iPhone users only get them if they save the site to their home screen — most won't do that without prompting.
- Users have to actively say “yes” to notifications. Industry rates: 30–50% say yes on a computer, 10–25% on a phone.
- If a user clears their browser or uninstalls, notifications silently stop working — you won't know.
- Needs to be built — about 1–2 weeks of dev work.
- Won't reach lapsed users (they've usually lost the notification setup).

Recommendation: Start with text messages. Reaching every user matters more than saving money while you're still proving the product works. Once you're past ~3,000–5,000 active users, the text message bill gets big enough to make building web notifications worth the investment.

Total costs, both options compared

	1k users — SMS	1k users — Web	10k users — SMS	10k users — Web
Hosting + database	\$80–110	\$80–110	\$240–440	\$240–440
Notifications	~\$130	~\$0	~\$1,165	~\$0–10
Maps	~\$0	~\$0	~\$200	~\$200
Monitoring	~\$26	~\$26	~\$26	~\$26
Email (optional)	~\$15	~\$15	~\$50	~\$50
Total / month	~\$250–280	~\$120–150	~\$1,680–1,880	~\$520–730
Per user / month	~\$0.27	~\$0.13	~\$0.18	~\$0.06

Easiest way to lower costs: Send fewer texts. Cutting things like the weekend digest or only reminding users about plans they've RSVP'd to can drop the text-message bill by 30–40%.

1. **Hosting (Railway)** — The service that runs the app.
2. **Database (MongoDB Atlas)** — Where user data lives.
3. **Text messaging (Twilio)** — Only needed if you go with text notifications. Requires US carrier registration — start this early, it takes 1–3 weeks.
4. **Google Cloud** — For the venue search feature.
5. **Domain name** — Your web address.

6. **Error monitoring (Sentry)** — Recommended before you hit 1,000 users — alerts you to bugs in real time.
7. **Transactional email (Postmark or Resend)** — Optional — only if you want to send things like receipts or weekly digests by email.
8. **App Store accounts** — Only if you later decide to build a native iPhone/Android app. Apple is \$99/year, Google is \$25 one-time.

Keeping the app healthy & growing after launch

After launch, the app will need ongoing maintenance — bug fixes, security updates, small tweaks, and someone on call when something breaks. The standard approach is:

- **Monthly retainer** for the basics — bugs, updates, small fixes, monitoring. Plan for around \$2,500/month.
- **New features priced separately** — things like building web notifications or adding new flows are quoted as their own projects.
- **Make sure the contract covers** how fast bugs get fixed, that you own the code, that you own (and pay for) the infrastructure accounts, and how to hand things off cleanly if you ever switch developers.

Rule of thumb: Reserve ~\$2,500/month for maintenance, with a separate budget for any new features. Under-spending is fine. Over-committing on growth without dev support shows up as users churning when things break.

We can confirm this closer to when this V1 is complete.